

ARUN KUMAR

J.P. NADDA, *63* | BJP
Minister of Health & Family Welfare

↘ **A steady progression** Born in Patna, Nadda holds an LLB from Himachal Pradesh University. It was at the latter that he began his political career with ABVP. In 1991, he became the president of the BJYM, the BJP's youth wing

↘ **Minding health and party** The national-level swimmer has been health minister from

Ministers of State



ANUPRIYA PATEL, *43* | APNA DAL (S)

↘ **Spirited ally**
As MoS Health, the LSR graduate had earlier supported the Surrogacy Bill that banned commercial surrogacy in India

AGENDA NDA GOVERNMENT

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THE HEALTH MAKEOVER

Providing adequate and quality healthcare to a large population is a challenge. The immediate task is to provide affordable treatment and tackle the burden of spiraling non-communicable diseases

By SONALI ACHARJEE

India's healthcare system and parameters have improved in the past decade. We have implemented the world's largest insurance scheme, improved doctor-patient ratio and begun reducing critical indicators such as maternal and child mortality and the burden of various diseases. However, if the country is ever to be at par with advanced healthcare systems such as the US, Japan or the UK, there has to be more financial investment. According to the medical journal *Lancet*, government spending on health has declined, hovering at a meagre 1.2 per cent of the GDP in the past few years. The government, though, says its expenditure has increased, from 1.13 per cent in 2014-15 to 1.35 per cent of the GDP in 2019-20. This is expected to hit 2.5 per cent by 2025, as per the National Health Policy, 2017.

Aside from investment, India also faces an acute crisis of specialist doctors—oncologists, cardiologists, endocrinologists, pulmonologists—and superspecialists like interventional cardiologists, gynaecological oncologists and so on. "The burden of cancer is higher than the number of oncologists we have in the country. If one is to tackle the disease, it is critical to have enough treating doctors," says noted oncologist Dr Ashok Vaid.

Lastly, the country faces the threat of a changing culture and environment. A sedentary lifestyle, air pollution, climate change with hotter summers and increasing exposure to pathogens of animal origin are huge risks. They also increase the severity of non-communicable diseases like cardiovascular disease, diabetes and obesity, in all of which India has high global burdens. To combat these ills, experts say that the government must focus on improving public communication, increasing hospital beds, doctors, nurses and technicians. ■